NYT Daily Briefing — 2026-10-22

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tl;dr: An American envoy stood beside Vladimir Putin and called him a humanitarian. In the same fortnight, Ukraine's armed drones lost their satellite link and fell out of the sky. Twelve days before the midterms, the President sits at 36 percent approval and is spending $277 million. A New Mexico judge fined Meta $25 billion for 43 million privacy violations. A Venezuelan billionaire's family paid Alina Habba more than $50 million and got a pardon. Israel votes October 27 and Palestinians, who cannot vote, say the result is existential. A drone killed more than 150 people at a market in Abyei.

Cluster 1: Geopolitics & International Affairs

Thematic hook: The week's real territorial change was a bandwidth allocation — and the war that followed it is being settled by the patron's domestic politics, not by either army.

Articles: #1, #2, #5, #7, #8, #9, #10, #11, #13, #14, #15, #29

Witkoff Calls Putin a 'Humanitarian' While Collecting a Prisoner (#1): In St. Petersburg, Steve Witkoff thanked Putin for releasing Stephen Hubbard, a 74-year-old teacher held more than four years on charges the State Department calls fabricated, and told him: "You are a humanitarian also, sir, and I salute that." The sentence landed because Putin is wanted by the International Criminal Court — an institution the President sanctioned this month. The release arrived after a direct personal appeal, and it sits inside a payment schedule that includes Russian diesel purchases, suspended sanctions, and a public call for Ukraine to replace its president. The praise cost nothing and bought a campaign deliverable.

Insults Are a One-Way Street (#2): Peter Baker's memo documents the rule precisely: the President may attack any leader, but a leader who replies has committed an offense. In Oslo, Witkoff and Jared Kushner told Zelensky that his tone had infuriated the President; Zelensky answered "I never said that," then emerged to thank Washington for restoring intelligence help. The asymmetry is the policy: warmth is reserved for adversaries, and allies are managed as subordinates who must absorb correction without comment.

Starshield Went Dark and the Drones Fell (#5): A Ukrainian commander says dozens of armed drones lost their link to pilots mid-flight and many simply dropped, destroying more than $1 million of weaponry and halting nearly all operations for three days. Starshield is a Pentagon-funded satellite network, a sibling of Starlink — which means the dependency was architectural, not contractual. The administration has denied changing service and claimed it was restored; Ukrainian officials believe the throttle was punishment for refinery strikes. Either way, Kyiv now knows its drones fly on a permission it does not hold.

Palestinians Watch an Election They Cannot Vote In (#7): Israelis call October 27 the most important election in their history; Palestinians in Gaza and the West Bank, who have no ballot, largely agree. "These elections are existential," says Nidal Kuhail, 32, living in a 6-by-4 meter tent with three sisters and his parents. Netanyahu vows no Palestinian state and has accelerated West Bank settlement; his main rival, Gadi Eisenkot, also rejects statehood but promises to curb settler violence and engage the cease-fire plan. That narrow difference is what the unenfranchised are reduced to calculating on.

An American Nominee Detained During the Olive Harvest (#8): Brad Lander, a Democratic House nominee in New York, was held about three hours by the Israeli military while harvesting olives with Palestinian farmers in the West Bank; dozens of other volunteers remained in custody. The harvest is an economic lifeline for West Bank villages, and settler attacks have spiked in recent weeks. Lander, who has called the occupation "a crime under international law," says he was released with a warning that his actions were illegal.

A Market, a Drone, and 150 Dead (#9): A drone struck the Amiet market in Abyei without warning, igniting an inferno; more than 150 people were killed and the toll was expected to rise, with victims buried in two cemeteries and Doctors Without Borders treating more than 20 wounded. Both sides in Sudan's civil war now use drones to strike across vast distances, which means the front line has

effectively disappeared. There is no defensive number to report in this story because there was no defense.

Modi Locks Down Delhi to Hold His Coalition (#10): After youth protests over the voter roll, the Prime Minister sealed central New Delhi, detained protest leaders and rounded up demonstrators by the thousands — a better-prepared strategy than the batons and tear gas of the summer. Governing-coalition leaders are being fed a story that this is a power grab by traditional parties rather than a grass-roots movement. The phase has been won; whether the year has been is a different question.

China Calls the DeepSeek Ban Discrimination (#11): Beijing accused Washington of acting "under the pretext of so-called national security" after Homeland Security ordered DeepSeek products — and those of firms relying on its open-source models — removed from civilian agency systems. The order was issued in July and published this week, which is itself a signal: the technical decoupling is proceeding faster than either government's public story.

Macron Says Out Loud What Everyone in Europe Suspects (#13): Asked whether Trump dislikes France, Macron replied: "Well, one has to admit it. All the people who are speaking ill of our country right now are people who don't like our country." He accused leaders on both sides of the Atlantic of campaigning at France's expense during its worst rioting in years. Read strategically, this is Europe auditioning to become a second permission-holder — the only durable answer to a patron whose guarantees are revocable.

France Processes 2,500 Detainees Through Fast-Track Courts (#14): At the Tribunal de Paris, judges worked through a carousel of expedited hearings — a video student accused of throwing cobblestones, a teenager with seven stolen pairs of glasses, two friends who took whiskey for a birthday. More than 2,500 people had been detained by Tuesday. The throughput is the policy: the trials are the message, and the sentences are the receipt.

Readers on Abandoning Ukraine (#29): The letters page is unambiguous — "the United States' support for Ukraine in its courageous struggle against Russia's unprovoked war has been abruptly transformed from alliance to hostility," one reader writes of the editorial "Stop Appeasing Russia." The interesting fact is not the sentiment but its location: this is now the mainstream of the op-ed page, not its fringe.

The Pope Needs No Further Cancer Treatment (#15): Doctors say Pope Leo requires no additional treatment for lung cancer — a health update that removes an immediate question about his capacity to lead.

Cluster 2: US Politics & Domestic Policy

Thematic hook: Every institution in this section is being converted from a rule into a price, and the electorate has begun to notice the exchange rate.

Articles: #3, #4, #16, #17, #19, #20, #21, #37, #39, #40

A $50 Million Job and a Pardon (#3): Julio Herrera Velutini wanted a misdemeanor removed. His daughter gave a Trump-tied super PAC $3.5 million; that did not work. Then the family hired Alina Habba at $10 million a year for four years plus bonuses — more than $50 million guaranteed — to be general counsel of Concord Partners, a Florida company with no public business, registered days before she signed while still serving as U.S. attorney in New Jersey. The pardon came not long after. Every procedural box was checked, which is precisely what makes the story structural rather than scandalous.

36 Percent, Twelve Days Out (#4): The final Times/Siena poll finds 36 percent approval and 59 percent disapproval — the lowest of his presidency in this survey — with more than two-thirds of independents opposed and 69 percent disapproving of his economic handling. Likely voters prefer Democrats by 11 points in their districts. The number is not a forecast; it is a measurement taken at the moment the money is being spent.

The Court Sides With Transgender Prisoners, Without Explaining (#16): In an unsigned order, the Supreme Court blocked the administration from denying gender-transition care to federal inmates, with only Alito and Thomas dissenting in writing. About a thousand prisoners continue their prescriptions on the strength of a paragraph nobody signed. The outcome is humane; the form is an

institution that has learned it need not justify itself.

The President Wants the Press Out of the White House (#17): Trump repeatedly asked his press secretary to move reporters out of the Brady Briefing Room and floated replacing it with the indoor pool F.D.R. built in 1933, calling it her "last legacy." The proposal stalled. Read operationally, this is not a communications preference but the removal of an audit function — the only room where the administration's account of events becomes citable in public.

A Death Sentence Commuted on Thin Evidence (#19): Alabama's governor commuted a capital sentence citing weak evidence — a rare intervention in a state that executes frequently, and a reminder that clemency remains the last manual override in a system otherwise designed for throughput.

Video Contradicts ICE's Account (#20): ICE says agents did not strike a bicyclist with a vehicle in California; footage raises questions about that account and about the detention of a U.S. citizen. The pattern is now familiar: the agency's statement arrives first, the recording arrives second, and the official version has to be revised in public.

Mamdani Fires Without Stating a Rule (#21): Chiefs of staff for three deputy mayors were reassigned or dismissed and the mayor's advance-team head was fired, in a first-year shake-up reportedly driven by conduct and personal conflict. Turnover is normal; firing without an articulated rule is not, because it teaches the remaining staff that the criterion is the principal's mood.

A $277 Million Closing Argument (#39): Trump's operation is deploying $277 million in the final twelve days — roughly $23 million a day — centralizing party spending in one man's hands. Spending at that scale against a 36 percent approval rating is not persuasion; it is insurance against a base that has stopped believing the message.

Vance Defends an Ad Built on a Victim's Mother (#37): An ad from Vivek Ramaswamy, the Republican nominee for Ohio governor, features Amy Acton's estranged mother saying her daughter lied about her childhood; the mother's husband was charged with raping Acton when she was twelve. Ramaswamy is spending $4 million on it, and the Vice President calls criticism "whining." Child sexual abuse has become an unexpectedly central theme of the 2026 midterms.

A Suburb Walls Itself Off and Starts a Border War (#40): Bow Mar, Colorado, closed itself to cut-through traffic and exported the congestion to its neighbors. It is the smallest-scale version of the paper's largest pattern: a fix that works by moving the cost one jurisdiction over.

Prediction: Democrats will win a House majority in the November 3 midterms while falling short of the 11-point national margin, and Senate control will be decided by two states won by less than two points. *(Rationale: a 52–41 likely-voter lead is outside the range of the 2016/2020/2018 polling errors Cohn cites, but seat allocation runs through a map Republicans drew and defended through three cycles; a uniform 11-point swing would flip more Senate seats than any of those error scenarios permit.)* **Confidence: 75%** (high confidence)

Cluster 3: Business, Tech & Economy

Thematic hook: The paper's economics are less about growth than about who can switch a system off, and what a penalty is worth as a percentage of the harm.

Articles: #6, #22, #23, #24, #25, #26, #27, #28, #30, #36

Meta Fined $25 Billion for 43 Million Violations (#6): A Santa Fe jury found 43 million violations of New Mexico's consumer protection law, each carrying a penalty of up to $5,000; Judge Francis Mathew assessed $25 billion — about $581 per violation, or 11.6 percent of the statutory maximum — writing that the "extraordinary number of willful violations" supported "the highest level of penalty." The number is enormous and the ratio is small, which is the only part that matters to a company of Meta's size. A fine that cannot change unit economics is a fee schedule, not a deterrent.

Elon Inc.: SpaceX and Tesla Explore a Merger (#22): Musk confirmed that the boards of both companies have formed special committees to consider a combination worth perhaps $3.5 trillion at current values. He is chief executive and largest shareholder of both; he says he will recuse himself because he is a conflicted party, which is a sentence describing the problem it claims to solve. No committee can manufacture arm's length between a man and himself.

SpaceX's $14.5 Billion Quarter (#23): Revenue more than doubled on Starlink and AI products in the company's second report as a public business, and Musk marked the moment by pledging one share to "every kid in America" through a government savings program. The quarter is real; the $3.5 trillion valuation is roughly 60 times annualized sales, which is a statement about one person's judgment rather than about the business.

Black Unemployment Is the Tell (#24): The headline labor market looks sturdy; the Black unemployment rate says the experience underneath it does not, a pattern that has historically preceded broader weakness. Aggregate statistics have stopped transmitting to household experience — the same gap that runs through the entire political section.

G.M. Tries to Match Chinese Speed With A.I. (#25): General Motors says AI will halve vehicle design time to as little as two years, overhaul in-car computing, and cut battery costs, in response to BYD, Geely and Xiaomi rolling out new models at a pace established automakers cannot match. "The faster we can iterate, the better our products become," its chief product officer says. The admission inside the announcement is that Detroit's disadvantage is cycle time, not engineering.

Netflix's 28.7 Percent Margin Is Not the Problem (#26): Revenue rose 12 percent to $12.9 billion — the slowest growth in three years — while net income rose 44 percent to $3.7 billion. The company laid off 1,000 people and fired its chief content officer and top two film executives because attention hours have stalled in the U.S. and Canada. Management changed the organization rather than the strategy, while the P&L still looked excellent — which is when most companies refuse to act.

315,000 Barrels, Borrowed From Next Winter (#27): With heating oil prices a political problem twelve days before the vote, the administration will lend up to 315,000 barrels — 31.5 percent of the Northeast reserve — with deliveries due November 13 and repayment required before the next heating season. Analysts say the volume is too small to move prices. The announcement was sized for a news cycle, not for a market.

Britain Approves North Sea Gas, Calling It 'Pragmatic' (#28): Prime Minister Andy Burnham greenlit a long-stalled offshore gas project to reduce import dependence, paired with billions for renewables. Environmental advocates say it undercuts the country's emissions pledge. The politics are legible: energy security is now the argument that beats climate policy in a country whose industrial regions have been in decline for a generation.

The Doom Loop of the Customer-Service Chatbot (#30): A case for regulation: automated support systems that trap customers in loops with no route to a human, and a New York rule that would require one. This is the consumer-facing edge of the same dependency described in Cluster 5 — a system that works until it doesn't, and offers no door when it fails.

Alaska's Newsrooms Pool Resources to Cover a Senate Race (#36): With local outlets collapsing, Alaska's journalists have joined forces to cover the state's marquee contest. It is journalism as a cost-sharing arrangement — the only structure left when no single newsroom can afford the truth alone.

Prediction: Within thirty days, at least one breach attributed to the newly published PHP vulnerabilities will be confirmed at an organization with more than a million users, and Meta's $25 billion judgment will be stayed or reduced on appeal before any payment is made. *(Rationale: patches released alongside vulnerability disclosures create a reverse-engineering window measured in hours, and roughly 70 percent of web deployments cannot be inventoried quickly; separately, a state-court judgment of this size against a defendant with federal appellate resources is routinely superseded by bond pending review.)* **Confidence: 72%** (high confidence)

Cluster 4: Culture & Society

Thematic hook: The culture stories are all about the same thing — a person whose individual record outlives the institution that tried to price it.

Articles: #32, #33, #34, #35

Felicity Green Put the Miniskirt on Millions (#32): The Fleet Street fashion editor who brought the miniskirt to the mass market and helped define the look of 1960s London has died at 100. Her obituary is an argument about how style actually propagates: not from designers to customers, but through the editors who decide what a decade looks like.

Richard Riehle, 78, and the Durable Bit Part (#33): A character actor with hundreds of credits, best known as the doomed consultant in "Office Space," has died. The role outlived the film's box office because it captured something audiences recognized about being processed by a system — a theme this paper returns to in almost every section today.

Zara Larsson's Decade-Long Overnight Success (#34): A case study in patience and streaming strategy: a decade into her career, Larsson crossed into pop's top tier through the slow accumulation of a fan base rather than a single breakthrough. The music business now rewards compounding rather than hits, which is a quiet inversion of how stardom was manufactured for fifty years.

Knicks Tickets After the Title (#35): The economics of a season opener at Madison Square Garden show what a championship does to a fan's willingness to pay. It is the paper's cleanest example of the day's larger theme: a price that was always arbitrary becomes objective the moment scarcity is certified by an institution.

Cluster 5: Science, Health & Environment

Thematic hook: Three systems failed this week in the same way — nobody had inventoried the foundation until it moved.

Articles: #12, #18, #31, #38

A.I. Found the Flaw Under 70 Percent of the Web (#31): Researchers using OpenAI's models unearthed major bugs in PHP, software that by some estimates runs about 70 percent of websites and web applications, and governments in the U.S., Europe and Asia told organizations to install Wednesday's patches immediately. Because the patch is public, it is also a road map: hackers can reverse-engineer it and attack before installation completes. The NSA advised taking systems offline where patching is impossible — an instruction most organizations cannot execute, because they do not have an inventory of what they run.

Devon's Dark Sky Meets Europe's Largest Data Center (#12): Plans for one of Europe's largest AI data centers — 850 acres of farmland beside Great Torrington, population 6,000 — have triggered fierce opposition over noise, pollution and light. "We were utterly blindsided by it," says resident Giles Atton. The objectors include retired scientists and engineers who can read a planning document, which makes the usual dismissal of local resistance unavailable. The AI buildout's center of gravity is not capital; it is land, power and consent, and consent is the scarcest of the three.

Toledo's Tank: 1,000 Evacuated, 5,500 Gallons (#18): A chemical leak that began Tuesday night, possibly from an explosion at a transportation company, forced nearly 1,000 residents out and thousands more indoors, with complaints of burning eyes and coughing. A second explosion remained possible because the leaking tank sits beside others; the mayor said the 5,500-gallon tank would be drained within 6 to 16 hours. The response looks competent, and the underlying question — who inspected that yard, and when — has not been asked.

New York's Ambulances Are Getting Slower (#38): Response times have climbed sharply as hospital closures and staffing strains bite — a metric that converts management failures directly into survival probabilities. It belongs beside the PHP story: both are systems whose degradation is invisible until the moment someone needs them.

Prediction: Within six months, at least one European government will nationalize or preempt local planning authority over AI data-center siting, and the Devon project will be delayed past 2027. *(Rationale: the objecting population in these cases is unusually

capable of litigating, the grid connection requires state-level approval regardless of local planning, and the political cost of appearing to override a village of 6,000 has already been demonstrated in the U.K. and Ireland.)* **Confidence: 62%** (moderate confidence)

Prediction Summary Table

#	Prediction	Confidence	Rationale
1	Democrats win the House but underperform the 11-point national margin; Senate control decided by two states under two points	75%	Likely-voter lead outside the 2016/2020/2018 error range; seat allocation runs through a Republican-drawn map
2	A confirmed breach of 1M+ users traced to the PHP flaws within 30 days; Meta's judgment stayed or reduced before payment	72%	Public patch = reverse-engineering window; a judgment of this size is superseded by bond pending appeal
3	A European government preempts local planning on AI data centers within six months; Devon delayed past 2027	62%	Capable local opposition, state-level grid approval, demonstrated political cost of override
4	Starshield service is partially restored but never formally acknowledged, and Ukraine fields no equivalent substitute this year	65%	Dependency is architectural; no commercial alternative at scale; both governments benefit from ambiguity
5	Netanyahu's bloc loses its plurality on October 27 but no governing coalition forms that endorses Palestinian statehood	55%	Both leading candidates reject statehood; the unenfranchised are choosing between rates of settlement

Prepared from 40 stories in the October 22, 2026 New York Times print edition, analyzed through 5 persona lenses (Connector, Data Analyst, Philosopher, Strategist, Operator).

Observer Commentary

翟东升

翟东升观察：当制度开始给自己标价:

今天的《纽约时报》头版，几乎每一篇都是一张报价单。底层逻辑是：美国正在把过去靠"制度信用"免费提供的东西，一件一件拿出来卖。

先看那笔赦免。委内瑞拉银行家的女儿先给特朗普关联的超级政治行动委员会捐了350万美元，不够；再把哈巴（Alina Habba）聘为一家没有实际业务的佛罗里达公司的总法律顾问，年薪1000万美元、四年、加奖金超过5000万美元——签约时她还是新泽西州的联邦检察官。这不是腐败的问题，这是法律可执行性（legal enforceability）这个支柱在折价的问题。美元的价值来自美国制度的可信度：合同能不能执行、法律面前是不是人人平等、权力交接是否稳定。当赦免可以用一份雇佣合同买到，这个折价不会只停留在道德层面，它会缓慢地反映在长期国债的期限溢价里。市场是主权变迁的滞后指标，从来不是领先指标。

再看Meta那250亿美元。43 million次违规、每次法定上限5000美元，理论上限2150亿，实际判了250亿——11.6%，折合每次违规581美元。这不是监管的问题，这是立法者把2010年代的罚款上限写进法律、然后让2026年的行为按旧价目表结算的问题。罚款如果不能改变单位经济，它就只是一张收费单。制度熵增就是这样发生的：形式完好，内容已经变现，而且没人需要把它说出来。

最值得注意的却是那张"人道主义者"的照片。威特科夫在圣彼得堡当面称普京为"humanitarian"，换回一个74岁的教师。道德词汇被降级为交易的包装纸，这说明美国的道德信用账户已经不再计息——它只能一次性折现，不能累积。

还有那31.5万桶取暖油。储备一共100万桶，借出不到三分之一，11月13日前交付，下个取暖季之前必须归还。这是拿明年的寒冷为今年12天后的选举融资。一个连"enough"（足够）都不知道的国家，它的物理天花板已经不在外面，而在里面。

我的判断不变：这不是某个总统的问题，是主权信用货币体系在其末期必然出现的结构性现象。平行体系的建设不需要谈判，它从旧秩序的废墟里长出来。

金灿荣

金灿荣观察：美国人现在真的很焦虑:

各位朋友，今天的头版很有意思。三十六个百分点的支持率，十二天以后中期选举，然后特朗普花了2.77亿美元——一天2300万。你们记不记得，一个饭馆老板，菜还没炒好，先把桌子掀了？现在的情况是，桌子掀了，客人也走了，他还在往厨房里砸钱。

为什么会出现这种情况？这个事情其实很简单：美国的工业化空心化，最后一定会反映到政治上。你看通用汽车那条新闻，说要靠人工智能把新车设计周期从四年压到两年，为什么？因为比亚迪、吉利、小米两年就出一款车。通用自己承认了——它的短板不是工程师不行，是cycle time。工业化本体论讲的就是这个：霸权不是靠嘴硬维持的，是靠工厂里的机器、实验室里的技术和老百姓的饭碗撑起来的。饭碗没了，选票就没了。所以我们看到36%，看到独立选民三分之二反对，一点都不奇怪。

再看外交，这个更典型。特朗普对普京，称"人道主义者"，还感谢他放人；对泽连斯基，人家回一句嘴，就派威特科夫和库什纳到奥斯陆去训话，说你把总统惹怒了。欺软怕硬嘛——你对他好，他得寸进尺；你真跟他斗，他就怂了。可惜乌克兰不是中国，它没有那个体量，所以它只能"我们感谢美方"，然后把话咽回去。这就是战略相持阶段里，依附型国家的结构性悲剧。

最有意思的是那个"星盾"（Starshield）。乌克兰的无人机飞在天上，链接一断，一堆掉下来，一个下午损失一百多万美元。这说明什么？说明美国的"盟友体系"本质上是开关体系——开关在华盛顿手里，不在基辅手里。欧洲人现在也看懂了，所以马克龙在卡塔尔说"特朗普不喜欢法国"。欧洲要自己再拿一个开关，这是被逼出来的。

我们赢了？我不急着说这句话。我更愿意说：东升西降的趋势很清楚，但美国这个国家非常认力量，它还会折腾。中国要做的，就是把自己的事情做好——尤其是把工厂和实验室守住。这就是大变局的本质。

宋鸿兵

宋鸿兵观察：找出单点故障，就看懂了整个系统:

如果你把今天的新闻看作一个工程系统，它的核心问题只有一个：单点故障（single point of failure）到处都在，而且每一个都被当成了效率来设计。

先看"星盾"。乌克兰的无人机飞在空中，视频回传用的是五角大楼出钱的卫星网络，跟星链是姊妹系统。某一刻阀门被拧小了，几十架无人机掉下来，一个指挥官三天不能行动。这不是战术问题，而是整个系统的问题——这条链路只有一个阀门，而阀门不在用户手里。胡雪岩1883年垮台，不是因为他的商品不好，是因为白银的流动性被别人掐住了。今天掐的是带宽。金融高边疆讲的是控制清算和支付；信息高边疆讲的是控制链路与许可。逻辑完全一样：货币发行是人类社会最重要的权力之一，而今天"开关权"正在变成第二种同等重要的权力。

第二个单点故障更可怕。全球约70%的网站跑在PHP上，这个软件的关键漏洞被AI找出来了，补丁同一天公开。补丁一旦公开，就等于把攻击地图一起发了出去。这不是某个公司的问题，而是整个系统的问题：一个由志愿者维护的基础组件，承载着世界大部分的网页，几十年没有做过系统性审计，第一次全面审计是一个机器做的。系统的脆弱性从来不平均分布，它集中在没人愿意付费维护的地方。

第三个是价格系统。Meta被判250亿美元，43 million次违规、每次581美元。你看这个数字——判了法定上限的11.6%。只要罚款可以被计入成本，它就不是惩罚，是费用。
而与此同时，SpaceX一个季度145亿美元收入，合并估值喊到3.5万亿美元，大约是年化销售额的60倍。一边是真实的现金流被折价，一边是叙事被溢价。三变六反讲的就是这个：每一个假设都在反向。

我的结论很简单：美元环流正在逆转，不是因为别人要推翻它，是因为它自己的阀门太多、维护太少。
找单点故障，你就看懂了系统；今天这篇报纸，从头版到讣告，都在展示同一批阀门——卫星、补丁、储油罐、新闻发布厅。谁握着阀门，谁就是真正的主权者。

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